

World in Brief: Iran says it has closed Strait of Hormuz; negotiators travel to Switzerland



Photograph: Getty Images

Iran said it had closed the **Strait of Hormuz** because of what it called a violation of the latest ceasefire by Israel. Lebanon said Israeli air strikes killed at least 16 people, hours after the [ceasefire](#) was supposed to begin. Israeli officials said they were responding to attacks by Hizbullah. Iran added that, if the aggression continues, “further steps will be planned”.

J.D.Vance said on Fox News there was no evidence of Iran closing the Strait of Hormuz. The American vice-president said special envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner are in Switzerland for [negotiations](#) with Iran, that talks to end the war were possible on Sunday and that he would travel there “in the next couple of days”. Iranian state television said officials were traveling there for talks.

More than 100 Labour ^{mps} have called on Sir Keir Starmer to resign. Britain’s prime minister faces an imminent leadership challenge from **Andy Burnham**, Greater Manchester’s former mayor who was [elected as an mp](#) on Friday. Cabinet ministers are reported to have told Sir Keir he faces being forced out if he does not set a timetable for departure.

The spat has escalated between **Donald Trump** and **Giorgia Meloni**, over Mr Trump's claim that the Italian prime minister had begged him for a photo at a recent meeting. Ms Meloni had responded that "neither I, nor Italy, ever beg", but Mr Trump repeated his claim, saying she wanted to be friends to get her "numbers up". Ms Meloni responded again, saying he should focus on his own popularity.

Poland and **Ukraine** also entered a tit-for-tat row. When Ukraine named a military unit after a group of second-world-war-era fighters, heroically remembered in Ukraine but accused of genocide by Poles, Poland revoked its highest honour from Ukraine's president, Volodymyr Zelensky. Three top Ukrainian officials then returned awards given by the Poles. Poland has been a staunch supporter in Ukraine's war with Russia.

America will phase out funding for its **AIDS**-relief programme in **South Africa**, in place since 2003, because the country has failed to "make demonstrable progress on policy requests by the administration". Mr Trump has accused South Africa's government of fuelling violence against the country's [white minority](#) and seizing land without compensation. As much as 12% of the population has **HIV**.

The United States secured a spot in the knockout phase of the **World Cup** after a 2-0 victory over Australia. It is the first time since 1930 that America, [the tournament's](#) co-host, has won its opening two games of a men's World Cup. They may soon be joined in the last 32 by Brazil, which beat Haiti 3-0. Scotland, meanwhile, suffered a 1-0 loss to Morocco.

Word of the week: *Chidehao*, Chinese for "eating well", and what China's Communist Party wants people to do more of. [We explore the Californication of middle-class Chinese diets.](#)

*How well do you know the week's news? Test your knowledge in
[our quiz](#).*

Is Iran heading for a windfall?



Photograph: Reuters

[Donald Trump's deal](#) involves a bold bet: dangle enough cash before Iran's regime and it will play ball. The [memorandum of understanding](#) between America and Iran makes a few demands—that Iran should open the Strait of Hormuz and abandon its nuclear programme—in exchange for big inducements. America will end its blockade of Iran's oil exports, waive sanctions on its crude and release billions of dollars frozen in foreign banks. Later on, if Iran co-operates, it proposes an eye-popping prize: a \$300bn reconstruction fund, developed with “regional partners”.

Iran's economy has been [battered by the war](#). Its bombed-out industries will take years to recover. Inflation is 84% year on year and perhaps 2m people have lost their jobs. Its leaders, therefore, will be pleased with this deal. Even if Mr Trump's quixotic \$300bn fund never materialises, the resumption of oil exports and sanctions relief will give the regime a rush of cash. Don't expect the country's immiserated population to see many of the benefits.

Why this El Niño could make history



Photograph: AP

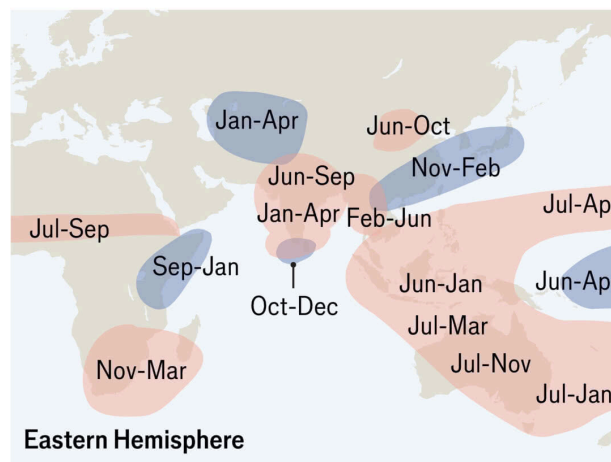
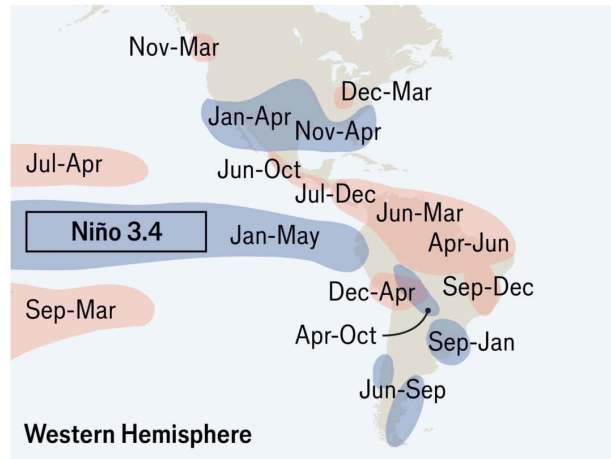
El Niño, a recurring climatic pattern that alters the weather all over the world, has begun. It is driven by a shift in the winds above the eastern Pacific, which draws a band of warmer-than-average surface water into the “Niño 3.4” region (see map). The strength of El Niño is measured by how much warmer the water gets.

Anything above a 2°C rise over the long-run average is considered strong.

This one is [shaping up to be a whopper](#). Forecasts for the rest of this year and the start of 2027 suggest a rise in sea-surface temperatures of more than 2.5°C, and perhaps even 3°C. That would be unprecedented in the 75 years for which scientists have been keeping records. El Niño causes a vast redistribution of heat and moisture, resulting in droughts, heavy rain, heatwaves and wildfires. There are ways to blunt the impact, such as planting more drought-resistant crops. But the time to start is now.

El Niño's typical impact on rainfall, by season

■ Drier ■ Wetter



Source: International Research Institute for Climate and Society

Bring me your huddled Afrikaners



Photograph: Getty Images

For a long time America's refugee system was extremely generous, resettling more people than all other countries combined. As the world marks World Refugee day on Saturday, the picture looks very different. Not only are America's admissions way down—around 7,000 this year so far, compared with a pre-Donald Trump annual average of 79,000—they are almost all [white Afrikaners](#) from South Africa.

Mr Trump says Afrikaners are victims of a “genocide”. He also says they suffer race-based discrimination in higher education and hiring. The latter might have some truth, but elides a complicated history. Laws were introduced to help [redress the wrongs of apartheid](#)—until 1994, for instance, blacks were not allowed to vote. To qualify as a refugee you must show a credible fear of oppression or ill treatment. Under Mr Trump, that is easier than ever for Afrikaners. All you have to do, says a recent arrival, is suggest you are scared of “your future persecution”.

As different as night and day



Photograph: Annabel Moeller/Courtesy of Vue Lumiere

It is not [Virginia Woolf's](#) finest novel. "Night and Day", a social comedy, follows the lives of Katharine Hilbery, an upper-class woman who longs to be an astronomer, and Mary Datchet, a suffragette. The book, published in 1919, was shunned by critics: E.M. Forster wrote that it was Woolf's "least successful" work. On Goodreads, a book website, modern readers describe it as "beyond boring".

It may seem odd, then, that "Night and Day" is Woolf's first novel in decades to be adapted for the big screen. The film, released in cinemas in Britain this week, makes several changes to the plot: chiefly, it is more preoccupied with astronomy than any love affair. Surprisingly, this adjustment lifts Woolf's tale. Haley Bennett, as Katherine, is giddily thrilled about pursuing her passion; the ensemble cast, which includes Jack Whitehall and Timothy Spall, provides welcome comic relief. The result is far from boring.

Weekend profile: Haiti's diaspora World Cup squad



Photograph: Getty Images

It is not unusual for [World Cup](#) footballers to live and play outside the nation they represent. But most at least return to train ahead of the tournament. Not so for Haiti's team. The Caribbean country, which is playing in the World Cup for the first time since 1974, is dominated by [criminal gangs](#). Violent crime is rife and the state barely functions. As such, the national team almost exclusively consists of players based elsewhere. Many have never been to the country. Haiti had to play their home qualifying matches 500 miles away in Curaçao.

Only one of the team lives in Haiti. Woodensky Pierre, a midfielder, plays for local champions Violette Athletic Club. He was late joining his teammates at their training camp in Florida because of an American travel ban on Haiti. He was only given a visa on June 1st.

The team's French coach, Sébastien Migné, has never been to Haiti either. But he is used to leading teams from volatile places. He has spent much of his career in Africa, and was the assistant coach for the national side of the Democratic Republic of Congo when the country was caught in an internal armed conflict. To build a Haitian team he persuaded talented footballers who are eligible to play to sign on. The two most famous members of the Haitian squad, Jean-

Ricner Bellegarde and Wilson Isidor, are French-born Migne converts. The pair spent last year in the English Premier League.

One of Haiti's squad, Duckens Nazon, escaped another conflict in his journey to the World Cup. Last year the striker signed for Esteghlal, one of the most successful clubs in Iran. When war began in February, Mr Nazon had a hair-raising trip out of the country.

But Haiti's footballers have come together more successfully than its politicians. The country has cycled through transitional councils since gangs forced out the last elected government in 2016. Order, such as it is, depends on a UN-backed Gang Suppression Force. America bankrolls that mission, yet shows little sympathy for Haitians' plight. Donald Trump's administration has tried to strip some 350,000 Haitians in America of their protected status—a move blocked, for now, by a federal judge.

The conflict-racked country could do with a brief burst of elation. But Haiti's World Cup is unlikely to last long. They share a group with Brazil (five-time winners) and Morocco (semi-finalists in 2022). They lost against Scotland on June 14th. But Mr Migné knows that the World Cup can defy logic. In 2022 he was the assistant coach for Cameroon. The team provided one of the tournament's most joyous moments when they beat Brazil 1-0 with a last-minute winner. Haitians will dream of a similar upset this year.

Mini crossword

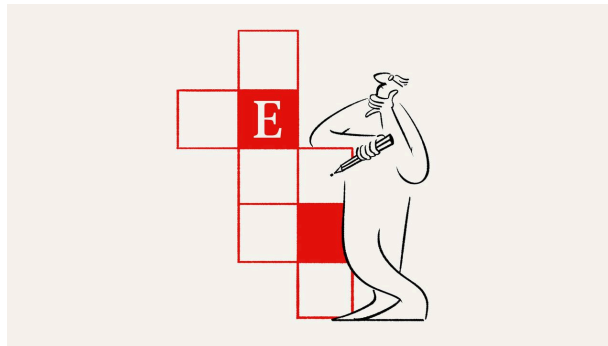


Illustration: The Economist

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Charles Rex heads American bottom? A bit rude (5)

2 across - Average and not very nice (4)

3 across - Propeller spins both ways (5)

1 down - Dubious imp hacker gets Intel, for instance (9)

Straight clues

1 across - Crude or insensitive (5)

2 across - The most average average (4)3

3 across - Rotating mechanism (5)

1 down - Nvidia or Intel, for example (9)

Email all four answers, along with your home city and country, by 9am GMT on Monday to [\[email protected\]](#). We will pick three winners at random and crown them in Tuesday's edition.

The winners of this week's quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Willy Zimmer, Casper, Wyoming USA

Nalin, Tanjong Pagar, Singapore.

Frank Jansse, Brussels, Belgium

They all gave the correct answers of: a cow, the hand, School's Out, Thomas Haden Church, The Great Fire of London. The theme is bells: cow bell, handbell, school bell, church bell and fire bell.

The questions were:

Monday: *La vache qui rit* is a French cheese brand featuring which animal?

Tuesday: What title is given to the chief adviser to a ruler in the Game of Thrones series?

Wednesday: Which rebellious song was Alice Cooper's greatest hit?

Thursday: Who was nominated for his role as best supporting actor in the film Sideways?

Friday: What great event began at a bakery in Pudding Lane in 1666?

*I like people who refuse to speak
until they are ready to speak.*

Lillian Hellman